Episode 94: Once Upon a Time... (57) - *COO* How to Make Colour Direction Sheets Part 2

This year Tokyo also seems to be having a "dry rainy season." Every morning, weather forecasts often predict "it's going to rain! it's going to rain!" but in reality it's often just "sprinkling" and "drizzling" before stopping.

It's "probability of precipitation."

For example, let's say the probability of precipitation for a certain time period on a certain day is 70%. When we hear 70%, our instinct is to interpret it as:

"A tremendous amount of rain will fall"

But actually, this number means:

"The probability that rain will fall in such weather conditions is 7 out of 10"

It's only about the probability of "whether it will rain or not." Whether it's a heavy downpour or just sprinkling, rain is rain. If rain falls at all, "the forecast was correct!"

Don't you think that's kind of unfair? What do you think? (laughs)
Now then.

Continuing how to make colour direction sheets.

As I wrote last time, the base for colour direction sheet settings was organised by cutting and pasting from animation setting sheets. We write paint numbers on this.

There are long-established "conventions for writing paint numbers" in the industry. Whether this was started by whoever made Japan's first colour direction sheet, or came from overseas - I haven't researched it so I don't know the true origin, but the rule for expressing paint numbers in colour direction sheets is "darker goes below."

Long ago, when I was working at a finishing production company, I was teaching a newcomer how to read colour direction. After hearing my explanation, they said "Ah, so shadows become the 'denominator'?" which made me think "Oh, I see, exactly." It's just like fraction notation. The denominator is darker than the numerator.

Where and how to write numbers on colour direction sheets:

First, draw lines from the parts you want to colour direct to empty space outside the artwork. At the end of those lines, add paint number instructions. Write the "normal colour" number, draw a line below it, and write the "shadow colour" number below the line. If there's a "second shadow" (shadow of the "shadow colour," also called "two-level shadow"), draw another line below the "shadow colour" and write the number. Incidentally, "highlight colours" are written diagonally above the "normal colour" number with symbols like [Hi.].

Not just Toei Animation (東映動画) works, but other companies' works also generally used the same notation. This is actually important.

Finishing work often involves multiple finishing production companies working in parallel like a human wave, and finishing production companies themselves often handle multiple production companies' works simultaneously. For example, one finishing production company might be simultaneously working on Company A's Work A and Company B's Work B. If colour direction sheets are made with unique notation methods for each work, workers can get confused. The result: silly mistakes occur → redo work.

To prevent this, notation specifications should follow the same rules. Many people in charge of colour direction and colour design were finishing company alumni (I was too), having experienced such struggles and problems firsthand. So they naturally converged toward "industry standard" colour direction notation. Easy-to-read, mistake-resistant direction sheets became one theme.

These rules remain basically the same even with today's digital colouring.

(09.07.09)